



Indians who live here (there are about 800 of them left) are bound up completely with these reeds. They not only use them to form the ground they walk on, but also bind them together to construct simple shelters, weave

them into mats, build rafts and boats with them, burn them as fuel, drink a healing tea made with their flowers, and even prepare their soft hearts as an asparagus-like vegetable to accompany their meals.

MENDING NETS

A few decades ago there was a thriving fishing industry in the Uros Islands, but this, like many other traditional trades and customs, has been eroded by technology and tourism. Today, any fish the people catch is mainly for their own meals, or to use as barter on the mainland.



NATURAL PRESERVATION

Fresh fish would quickly spoil in the strong sun, so the Uros people preserve some of their catch by cleaning it, then spreading it out on the ground to dry.



COLD AND BRIGHT

Because Lake Titicaca is so far above sea level—about 12,500 ft (3,800 m)—it is chilly all year round, so the people wrap up well in woolen clothing. Hats keep their heads warm and protect them from the sun.



Observation platform